Discussion of "Preserving Male Representation: Gender Quotas and Bureaucratic Performance in China"

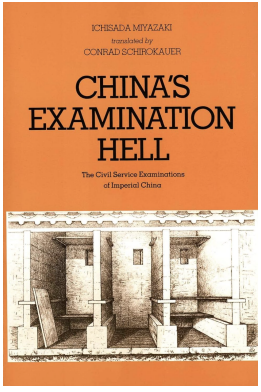
Sam Gyetvay

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Long history of excluding women from the Chinese civil service

"Competition for a chance to take the civil service examinations began, if we may be allowed to exaggerate only a little, even before birth. On the back of many a woman's copper mirror the five-character formula 'Five Sons Pass the Examinations' expressed her heart's desire to bear five successful sons. **Girls, since they could not take the examinations and become officials** *but merely ran up dowry expenses, were no asset to a family; a man who had no sons was considered to be childless.* **People said that thieves warned each other not to enter a household with five or more girls because there would be nothing to steal in it**. *The luckless parents of girls hoped to make up for such misfortune in the generation of their grandchildren by sending their daughters into marriage equipped with those auspicious mirrors."*

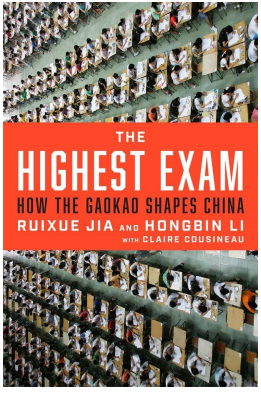
— Miyazaki (1976), *China's Examination Hell*



Meritocracy, exams, and corruption

"The term [Meritocracy] was coined by Michael Young in a satirical book published in 1958 known as The Rise of Meritocracy. Young constructs a dystopian society stratified by 'merit' and 'intelligence' to critique England's ... system of education, which sorted students into educational tiers based on an exam that they sat for as children. ... [A] true meritocracy is more myth than reality given the unequal socioeconomic realities and limited social mobility that persist across global societies. In the United States, these beliefs have given rise to highly controversial policies like affirmative action. ... We suggest that **the exams at the heart of China's culture are necessary in the face of weak institutions influenced by connections and corruption**. *Together,* **these forces ultimately drive citizens to buy into a single-score system to ensure the transparency and objectivity they are unable to find elsewhere**."

— Jia & Li (2025), *The Highest Exam*



Quotas preserving male representation

Entry-level hiring in Chinese civil service is a highly meritocratic "single-score" system

Since 2011, ranking of applicants based on National Civil Service Examination score. An "interview score" determines who gets hired among top-ranked candidates

- Women account for 65% of new hires since 2011

In 2016, some county tax bureaus begin to implement "one-for-one" quota system

- Post two vacancies for each position: one for men, one for women

Unlike in U.S., where proponents of affirmative action argue race-blind meritocracy will perpetuate underrepresentation of minorities, in China, quotas used to slow-down the increasing representation of women under gender-blind meritocracy

This paper

Collect data on when county tax bureaus implemented quotas

Matched diff-in-diff comparing counties that implemented quotas to observably similar counties that did not

Quotas reduced female share of hires

- decline from 67% of new hires to 53.9%
- NCSE cut-off score drops for men, rise slightly for women
- -15% fewer applicants (consistent with some women being discouraged from applying)

Tax collection less effective after adopting quotas

- tax revenue -4.7% ($\approx$ \$4M per county-year)
- despite increase in GDP relative to controls!
- administrative approvals also fall
- largest effects in high-corruption and heavy-drinking counties

This discussion

Very nice paper!

- Connecting gender quotas to measurable bureaucratic productivity
- Novel (if slightly disturbing) policy

I particularly applaud the heroic data collection

- web scraping thousands of positions
- collection of county-level tax revenue panel from yearbooks

My discussion will focus on two distinct-but-related issues:

1. Magnitudes: are they plausible?
2. Identification: does the parallel trends assumption hold?

Magnitudes

A typical bureau has $\sim$150 employees, hires $\sim$5 people a year, and collects $\sim$650M RMB in total, so $\approx$ 4.3M per employee

Pre-quota: out of 5 hires, $\approx$ 3.4 are women and 1.6 men

Post-quota: $\approx$ 0.7 women per year are replaced by men. After 3–4 years, $\approx$ 2–3 more men/fewer women hired (about 1.5–2% of staff)

Estimated revenue loss: 4.7% $\approx$ 31M RMB per year

This implies that each man hired in place of a woman reduces revenue by $\approx$ 10–15M RMB, which is over 2$\times$ the average tax revenue per employee

Even if these men did not collect any tax revenue, losing 2–3 workers out of 150 should reduce tax revenue $\leq$ 2%

Estimates appear to require large bureau-wide spillovers (corruption?)

Identification

Parallel trends assumption:

> *Counties that adopted quotas would have seen the same changes in tax revenue as observably similar counties that never adopted it*

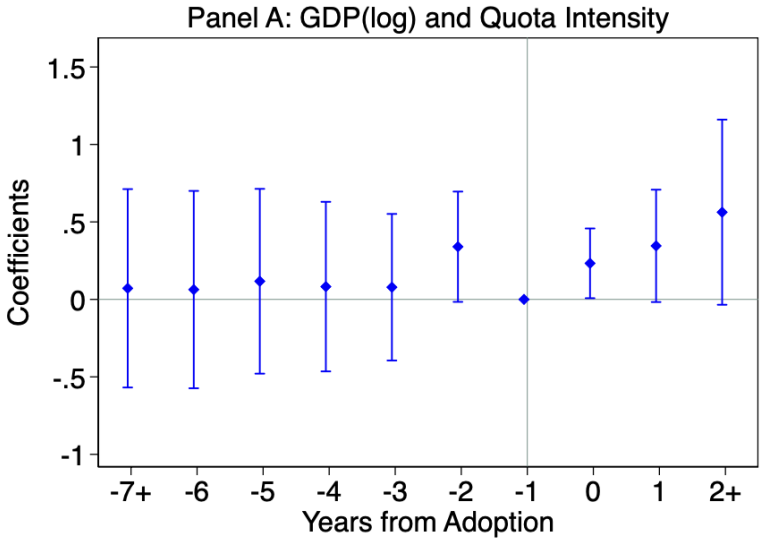
Pre-trend tests in the paper look good, but PTA needs to hold after treatment too

One way to test PTA post-treatment is to look at outcomes that quotas cannot plausibly affect, e.g., GDP, population

At least one such "placebo" (log county GDP) is in the paper. Estimates are noisy, but point estimate is large and positive

- on one hand, good: the negative tax revenue effect is not due to spurious contemporaneous decline in economic activity
- on the other hand, requires even bigger spillovers to explain tax revenue estimates: we would expect tax revenue to increase with GDP

Placebo: effect of gender quotas on log county GDP



Some suggestions

Absorb more time-varying county-level shocks

- Adding city-level time trends attenuates estimates
- Additional time-varying city-level shocks? City-year fixed effects?

Normalize by measure of tax "base"

- Tax revenue = tax efficiency $\times$ tax base
- Could get more precision + more parallel trends

Alternative treatment measurement

- Pool all men and women who apply for same posisition
- Measure treatment as number of men hired (women not hired) because of quota

Incorporate "interview score"

- How do employers screen on NCSE v.s. interview score for men and women?
- Not gender-blind!

In conclusion

Very nice paper!

With some more care to nail and/or justify magnitudes of estimated effects, would be a great contribution

Thanks a lot for the opportunity to discuss it :-)

Concluding quote:

> *The very idea that everyone should be eligible for the examinations, regardless of family background or lineage, was incomparably forward-looking in its day. . . . Compared with European institutions, it was extremely progressive at its beginning—and very far behind the times at its end."*
>
> — Miyazaki (1976), *China's Examination Hell*